In Oppenheimer, Bohm found a kindred spirit: a Jew from the East Coast who wanted to tackle the largest outstanding problems in theoretical physics, and who was also interested in a wide range of intellectual pursuits beyond physics. But there were also profound differences between Bohm and Oppenheimer: most notably, while Bohm's family was solidly working-class, Oppenheimer came from a wealthy, well-connected family in the Manhattan social scene. Despite the anti-Semitic "Jewish quotas" that existed at the time, Oppenheimer had managed to go to Harvard for his undergraduate degree. After graduating summa cum laude in three years, he went off to Europe and earned his PhD under Max Born. Later, Oppenheimer spent time working with Pauli in Switzerland, and, though he never studied in Copenhagen, Oppenheimer met Bohr and came to know him quite well. When Oppenheimer—or "Oppie," as he was known to his friends and students—came back to the United States, he set to work turning Berkeley into the first great department of theoretical physics in the country. By the time Bohm showed up in 1941, physicists in Berkeley knew that "Bohr was God and Oppie was his prophet," as Joe Weinberg, one of Oppie's other graduate students, put it. When Bohm arrived, Weinberg set about converting the new student. "With Weinberg I had intense discussions of Bohr on complementarity," Bohm recalled later. "At that time, I was convinced that Bohr's approach was the right approach and for many years I continued with Bohr's approach.… I was carried away with it because Weinberg was a very intense, convincing person and since Oppenheimer was also behind it that gave it a lot of weight in my mind."

Quantum physics wasn't the only thing that occupied Bohm's mind in Berkeley. He was also keeping an eye on the war raging in Europe—and what he saw there made communism look good. "Until, say in 1940 or '41, I wouldn't have had much sympathy with the Communist Party," Bohm recalled later. "The thing that deeply impressed me was the collapse of Europe in the face of the Nazis, which I felt was due to the lack of will to resist.… I thought the Nazis were a total threat to civilization.… It seemed that the Russians were the only ones who were really fighting them. That was the main thing. Then I began to listen to what they said more sympathetically." Bohm joined the Berkeley campus chapter of the Communist Party in November 1942. But he found the reality of the party less appealing than the idea. "I began to feel that they did nothing but talk